Aunt Leaf

By Barbara Wiechmann

Note from the Author: **(pg 7-8)** *Aunt Leaf is a story about storytelling. It was never my intent to have one actor play one role. In the original production, three performers "shared" the entire script, shared the story. All performers played all roles, completely unbiased as to gender, race and age. A storyteller can play anything. If you envision the play as a solo performance or a storytelling play for 20, give it a try. The only limit should truly be your imagination.*

VOICE 1: **(Pg 11-12)** Do you know this story? Do you know the story of Aunt Leaf?

VOICE 2: The story of Aunt Leaf is also the story of a little girl. Annabelle Wood.

VOICE 1: Annabelle lived one hundred years ago in a house surrounded by trees on the banks of the Hudson River.

VOICE 2: In those days the river was just as wide and glittering as it is today, but the forests were thicker, wilder, more dangerous and more mysterious.

VOICE 1: Annabelle did not worry about this. She was 11 years old . . . she fished along the riverbank, climbed the branches of a big tulip tree and lived safe inside the house with her cheerful and talkative family.

VOICE 2: Annabelle rarely talked at all [and her] silence concerned her family.

VOICE 1: **(Pg 13)** One morning at breakfast Annabelle's father made an unusual announcement:

FATHER: My Great-Aunt Leaf has slipped on an acorn in that crazy house of hers in the woods. It isn't safe for her to live alone anymore! She'll have to come live with us.

VOICE 1: And so Aunt Leaf came.

VOICE 2: Annabelle's father opened the passenger-side door. . . Slowly, slowly out came a pile of blinking black rags.

VOICE 1: Aunt Leaf could have been eight trillion years old. Gnarled hands with long grey fingers stuck out of the sleeves of her stiff dress like twigs on a winter tree. She smelled like a swamp.

FAMILY: **(Pg 14-15)** *(except for ANNABELLE, in a sudden rush and overlapping)*

Hello, Aunt Leaf! You must be tired. Are you hungry?

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Do you like dolls? Do you know any riddles? Do you like pie?

AUNT LEAF: I want to go home! Take me home! Take me home!

VOICE 1: Annabelle's mother tried her best to make Aunt Leaf happy.

VOICE 2: She planned spontaneous family sing-a-longs

VOICE 1: Stuffed Aunt Leaf in a canoe and paddled her downstream for a picnic.

VOICE 2: Made exotic meals for Annabelle and her sisters to take up to her on decorative trays.

VOICE 1: But Aunt Leaf did not want any of it. Day by day she grew thinner. If she spoke at all it was to complain.

AUNT LEAF: The room is too hot!! The house has too many doors! My skin is just a bruise!

VOICE 1: One morning she just screamed.

VOICE 2: Only Annabelle continued to bring up the meals. Every morning silently up the stairs. And every evening down again with the untouched tray.

VOICE 1: It was the same every day. Every day. Till one night something different happened.

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *When you have an idea, how do you share it with someone else?*
ACTOR 2: *Wait, wait. I know the answer. You text them or email them.*
ACTOR 1: *Because technology is everything. It's fast, it's efficient. But somehow, it loses something in the translation.*
TOGETHER: *True human connection.*
ACTOR 2: *That's why we struggled so much during COVID when ALL forms of connection went digital.*
ACTOR 1: *Even these types of competitions – we missed the connection.*
ACTOR 2: *Jimmy Neil Smith, the Director of the International Storytelling Center explains: "There isn't a stronger connection between people than storytelling.*
ACTOR 1: *"Stories make us more alive, more human, more courageous, more loving." -- Madeleine L'Engle*
ACTOR 2: *"That's what storytellers do. Restore order with imagination. Instill hope again and again." – Walt Disney*
ACTOR 1: *Living things are filled with stories. When you sink your toes in the mud you're sinking in stories. When you lie breathing in the dark, you're breathing stories . . .*
ACTOR 2: *So today, we're going to tell you a story . . . A story about stories.*
TOGTHER: *Aunt Leaf by Barbara Wiechmann*

VOICE 1: **(Pg 15-16)** That night long after the rest of the family had fallen into deep sleep . . .

AUNT LEAF: *(calling far off)* Annabelle! ANNABELLE!

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VOICE 1: Annabelle hearing her calls jumped out of bed and ran to Aunt Leaf's room. Aunt Leaf met her at the door. Her twiggy fingers pinched Annabelle's wrist.

AUNT LEAF: Go! Quick Quick! Go-outside-see if you see! See if you see! Quick! Quick!

VOICE 1: So Annabelle ran down the stairs, out the back door, and into the dark of the lawn and the woods. *(she stands looking around in the dark)*

AUNT LEAF: **(Pg 17-19)** What do you see? What do you see?! *(ANNABELLE says nothing)* Anything!?

ANNABELLE: Nothing.

AUNT LEAF: I heard your Great-uncle Greenleaf whistling on the lawn. Just the way he used to. Whistling to his dog. Did you hear? *(ANNABELLE shakes her head)* He'll come back. You'll see him next time. If you move fast enough.

ANNABELLE: Aunt Leaf, I don't think so. I've been to the cemetery. I've seen his grave!

AUNT LEAF: *(pause)* People come back.

ANNABELLE: That's not real. That's only in stories.

AUNT LEAF: This is a story. *(beat)* Everything is a story.

ANNABELLE: This isn't a story.

AUNT LEAF: Yes, yes, yes, it is! Spiders, rocks, pinecones. Living things are made of stories -- filled with stories. When you sink your toes in the mud you're sinking in stories. When you lie breathing in the dark you're breathing stories . . . I heard my husband.

VOICE 1: Later that night Annabelle lay in bed thinking and rethinking.

ANNABELLE: What could it hurt to tell one little story. *(beat)* If it makes someone happy. . . What could it hurt to tell one tiny lie. . .

VOICE 1: **(Pg 20-21)** Day after day Annabelle's family talked and talked and Annabelle barely spoke at all, but now sometimes during the night she would wake up --

AUNT LEAF: Annabelle! Annabelle!

VOICE 1: -- run silently down the stairs, ghost like out the back door and began to do something she had never done before; she began to make things up:

ANNABELLE: *(reporting back to AUNT LEAF, tentatively at first, but with more and more*

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confidence) The clouds were moving very fast. *(AUNT LEAF nods)* I heard a dog bark across the river.

AUNT LEAF: That's a sign . . . What else?

ANNABELLE: **(Pg 22-23)** I found a bootprint in the mud!

AUNT LEAF: Yes! Yes!

ANNABELLE: I saw a shadow! Ripple across the grass in the moonlight- and something else. Smoke! Curls of blue smoke

AUNT LEAF: From his pipe tobacco drifting through the branches

ANNABELLE: Yes! It was him. Uncle Leaf. I saw his shadow. It was him! It was him!

AUNT LEAF: *(softly)* Bring me something from outside.

VOICE 1: **(Pg 24-25)** She pinned a swamp buttercup in Aunt Leaf's hair. Didn't Aunt Leaf look lovely? Didn't she seem young? Wasn't she happy?

AUNT LEAF: He built our house in the woods. Every morning he walked into the forest with his ax. Cut away the dead wood, made room for the new growth. Every night I waited for his footsteps. I have lit the fire for supper. I am wearing my new blue dress.

VOICE 1: **(Pg 26-27)** In the dark by herself Annabell began to see. The more she saw the more she wondered. The more she wondered the more she imagined. The more she imagined, the more she told.

ANNABELLE: I saw a pair of tall boots disappear into the twilight. I saw a wagging tail and the back of a dog. It was huge. . . as big as a pony. . .

VOICE 2: All that July, Aunt Leaf grew fat and hopeful on the small fibs Annabelle fed her.

AUNT LEAF: Wash my face. Hook my pearls. Open the window. The air smells sweet. I'll tell you a story . . . This is the story of Uncle Leaf and the summer the spiders came. . . This is the story of Uncle Leaf and the blizzard that covered the house . . . Uncle Leaf and the witch of the

VOICE 1: All that August, Annabelle looked at the way the fish jumped in the river, the way the screech owl sat on his branch in the dark. She looked for her Uncle Greenleaf's handsome eyes in the leaves and began to wish her own stories were true. Uncle Leaf hides himself in the shapes of animals and

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Athens woods. . . Uncle Leaf and the Bullfrog children . . .The mysterious lights . . . The water snake . . . the black ice . . . the fire ball . . . the wolves. . . birds . . . Uncle Leaf knows the secret language of the crows . . . Uncle Leaf knows every story ever told

VOICE 1: **(Pg 29)** Voices from the daytime world called to her as if through the thickness of dream . . .

MOTHER: Annabelle! You look pale. Are you all right?

TEACHER: Miss Woods! It is rude to yawn.

SISTER: Annabelle! Get up! We're late for school!

VOICE 2: **(Pg 31)** But Annabelle paid no attention . . . She was busy listening to another voice. A new one. Her own.

VOICE 1: And when October came, Annabelle was wandering farther and farther into the forest, staying out longer and longer. Bringing stories from the night to share with Aunt Leaf.

VOICE 2: **(Pg 33)** But as the leaves turned yellow and fell one by one onto the grey earth, Aunt Leaf herself spoke less and less.

VOICE 1: Sometimes she spoke and made no sense at all . . .

AUNT LEAF: Bats in the grass! Stop pinching me! Don't eat that egg! Poison! Poison!

VOICE 1: **(Pg 34-35)** But Annabelle didn't care. She came back from the woods every night shining and shivering, climbed the stairs to where Aunt Leaf was waiting and told stories till the old woman fell asleep.

ANNABELLE: *(very softly)* This is the story of the blue pebble. This is the story of the dark. This is the story of the deep **river.** This is the story of the moon.

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VOICE 2: Now came the bitter cold and one freezing night . . . Annabelle was not in her room.

FATHER: **(Pg 36-37)** Annabelle! Annabelle! My little girl is missing. My child is lost!

VOICE 2: Soon men arrived with lanterns and torches. They rowed out onto the river. They crisscrossed the fields on horseback. And they walked deep into the woods. . .

VOICE 1: Annabelle's mother put a vat of spiced cider on the stove and stirred and stirred so

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she would not be afraid.

SISTER: People come back. They do come back . . .

TRANSITION

They found Annabelle clad only in her nightgown, skin so white it was almost blue – almost green. They brought her home and bundled her into bed.

VOICE 2: **(Pg 40-41)** What is real and what is not?

VOICE 1: Annabelle did not know anymore. [She] was so sick that dreams overtook her. She slept and woke and slept but could not tell which was which. She thought she heard Aunt Leaf call – but was too weak to get up.

VOICE 2: What is real and what is not? [Finally she got better]

ANNABELLE: **(Pg 42-46)** *(rousing to look out the window)* What has happened? Weren't there leaves? Weren't the woods filled with animals and birds? Didn't we spend all night telling stories? Aunt Leaf! Aunt Leaf?!

VOICE 2: But only the snow answered, softy brushing the window with its icy crystals.

ANNABELLE: Aunt Leaf? *(long pause)* What happened? I made it up. Aunt Leaf is just an old woman asleep upstairs. I was sick and now I'm better. And I am almost 12. I made everything up! Aunt Leaf!

VOICE 2: Annabelle stood in Aunt Leaf's dark room. . .

ANNABELLE: Did you know it was snowing? I went out in the snow. I went out because I heard a man chopping trees. I knew who he was. Uncle Greenleaf! I saw him walk to the tulip tree and I was afraid. No! No! You can't have that one. It's mine! It's mine! One chop and it fell. Quiet. Like a cloud falling. It made no sound. He looked at me. Then he whistled for his dog and they walked back into the woods. But it was real. It was more than a story. Aunt Leaf! Aunt Leaf!

VOICE 2: Aunt Leaf did not move. *(ANNABELLE puts her hand up to AUNT LEAF's cheek)*

VOICE 1: Some things do not change when morning comes. Some things are not a dream. Annabelle sat looking out the window at the foggy world.

VOICE 2: Outside, the Tulip Tree lay on the white snow.

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VOICE 1: Downstairs, Aunt Leaf's body lay in a long black box.

VOICE 2: Do you know this story? Do you know the story of Aunt Leaf?

SOURCE INFORMATION

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